Finding Our Inner Voice

[Customer dedication message]

This was [Child Name]'s favorite park in all of [Hometown].

Swings squeaked.
Sneakers thumped.
Kids laughed and called, "Again, again!"

[Child Name] ran in, ready to play.

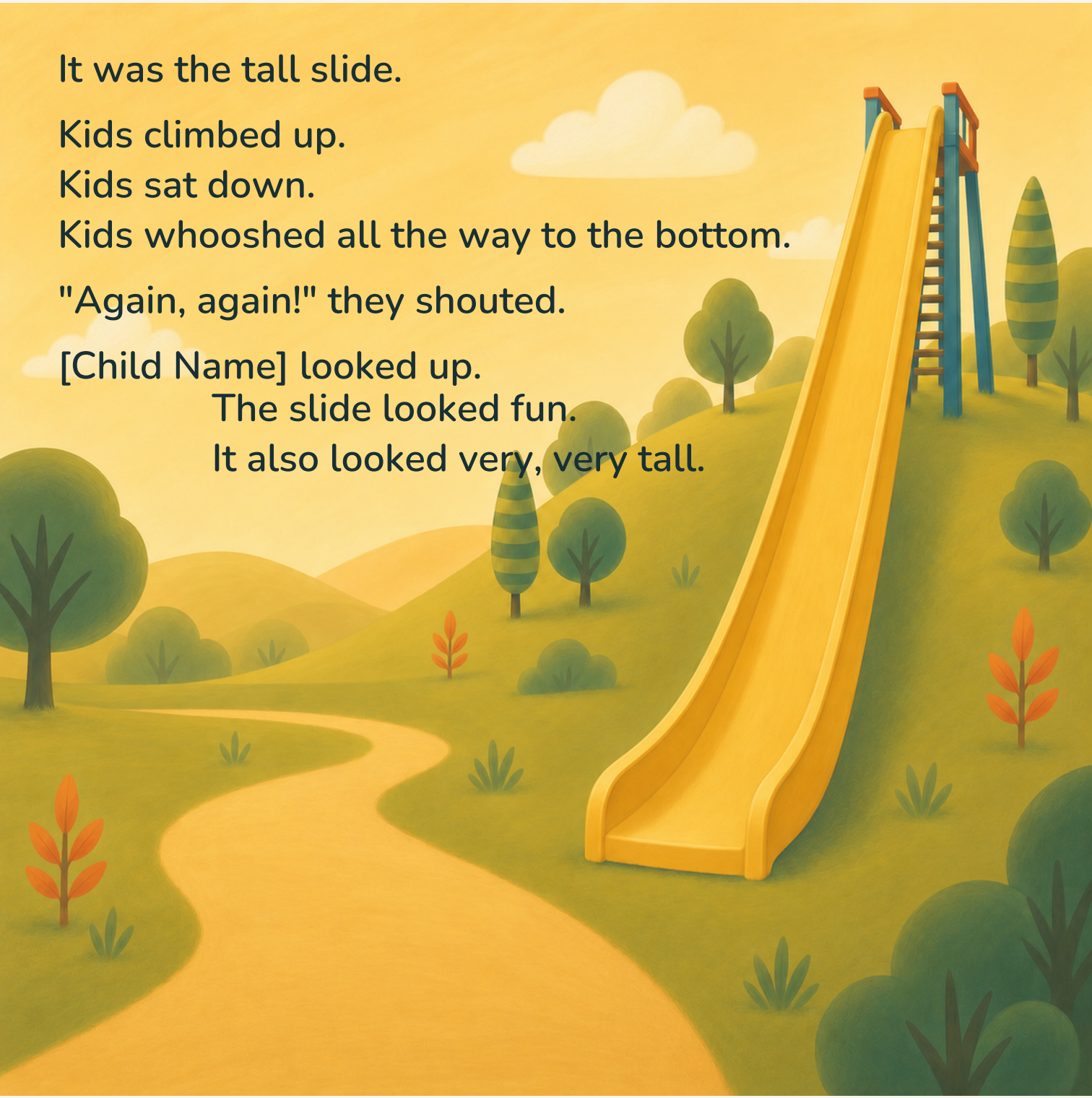
Swings.
Tunnels.
Sand.
A climbing wall like a mountain.
[Child Name] looked left, then right.
"What should I try first?"
Then came a whoosh from way up high.

It was the tall slide.

Kids climbed up.
Kids sat down.
Kids whooshed all the way to the bottom.

"Again, again!" they shouted.

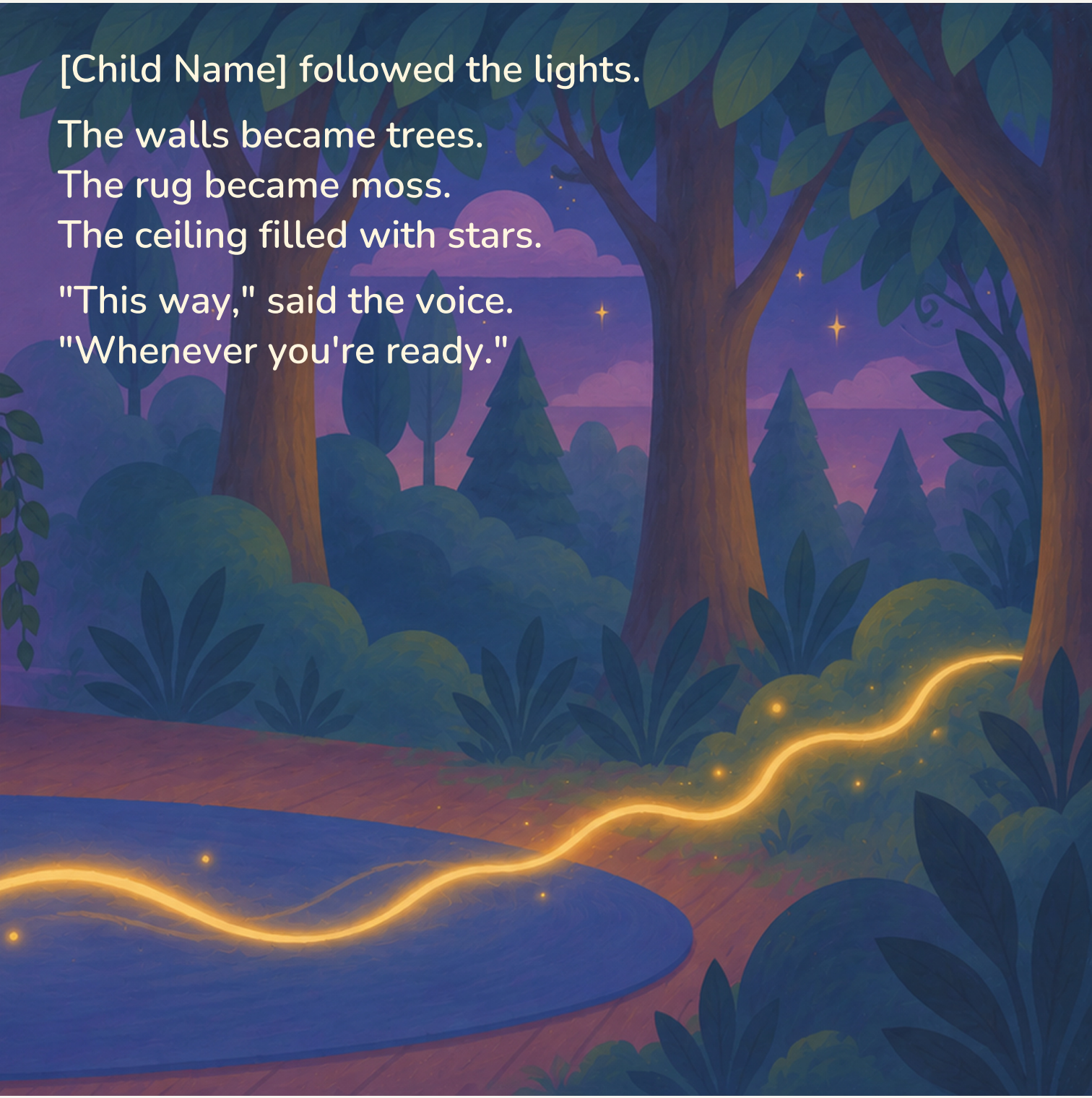
[Child Name] looked up.
The slide looked fun.
It also looked very, very tall.



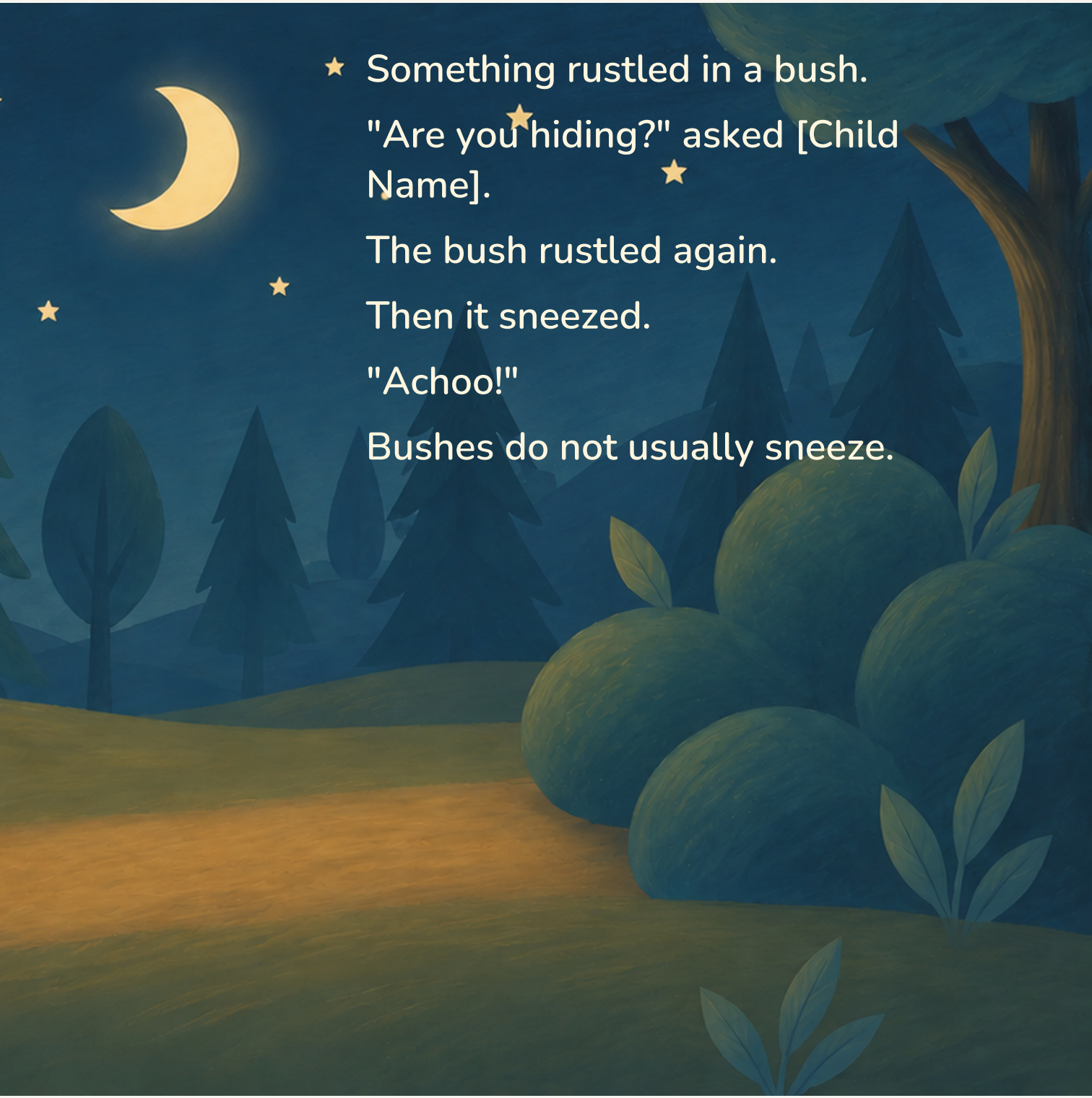
[Child Name] climbed to the top.
The slide looked even longer from here.
"Your turn!"
"Go!"
"It's fun!"
[Child Name]'s tummy flipped.
The top felt small.
The slide felt big.
[Child Name] did not know what to do.

That night, [Child Name] sat quietly on the bed.
The slide was far away.
The big feeling was still there.
"Your turn!" "Go!" "It's fun!"
[Child Name] took a deep breath.
The room grew quiet.
"That was scary," said a tiny voice.
[Child Name] nodded. "Yes."
"Oh! You can hear me now."

"Who said that?" asked [Child Name].
A light blinked beside the bed.
Then another.
Then another.
The lights made a path across the floor.
"Let's look together," said the tiny voice.


[Child Name] followed the lights.
The walls became trees.
The rug became moss.
The ceiling filled with stars.
"This way," said the voice.
"Whenever you're ready."

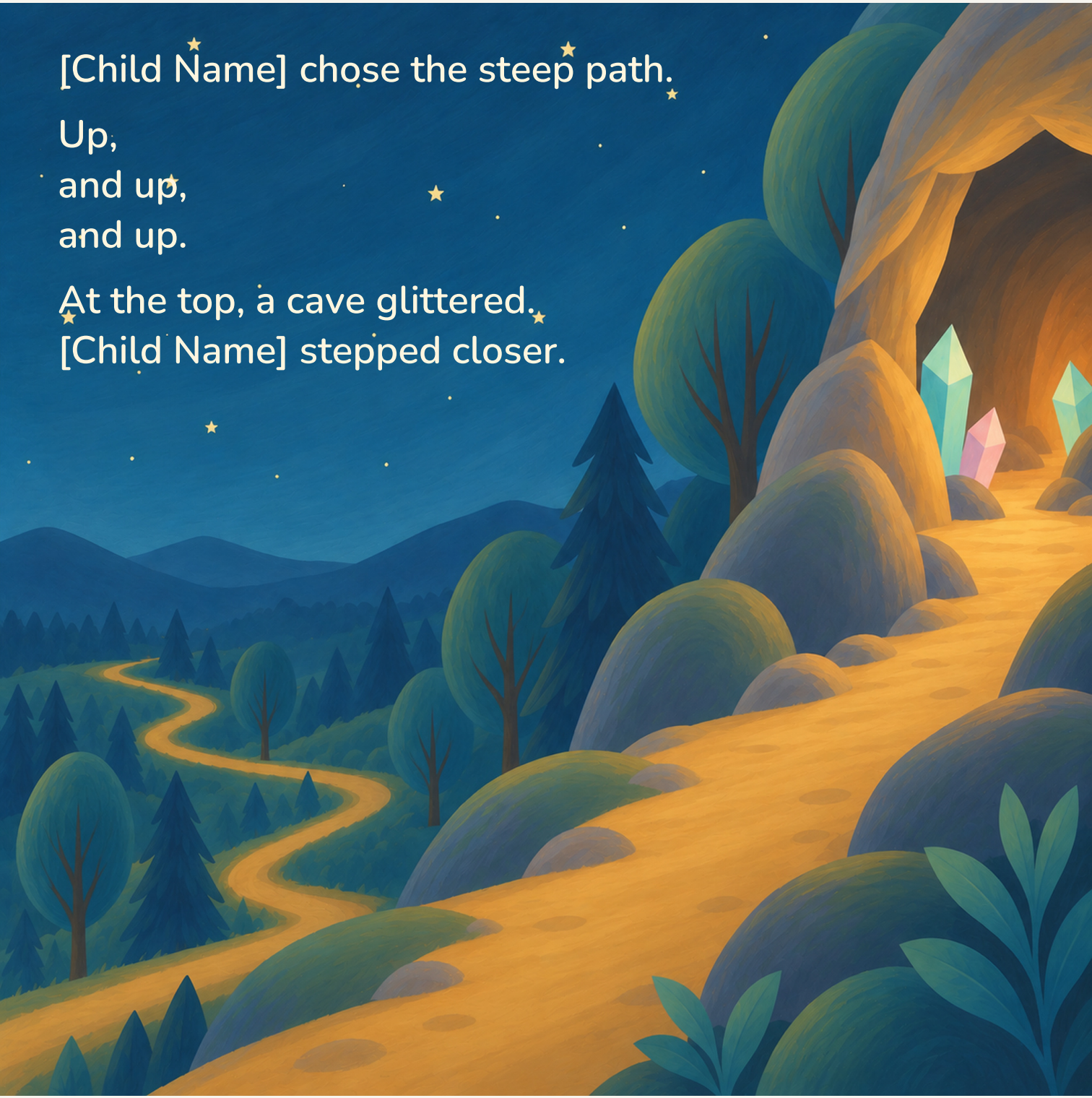
On the quiet path lay a clue:
[animal clue].
[Child Name] looked left.
Then right.
"Where are you?" called [Child Name].


Something rustled in a bush.
"Are you hiding?" asked [Child Name].
The bush rustled again.
Then it sneezed.
"Achoo!"
Bushes do not usually sneeze.

Before [Child Name] could peek,
voices called from every direction.
"This way!" blinked a star.
"No, this way!" puffed the wind.
"Hop!" said a mushroom.
"Skip!" said a stone.
A sign spun around.
"HURRY!"

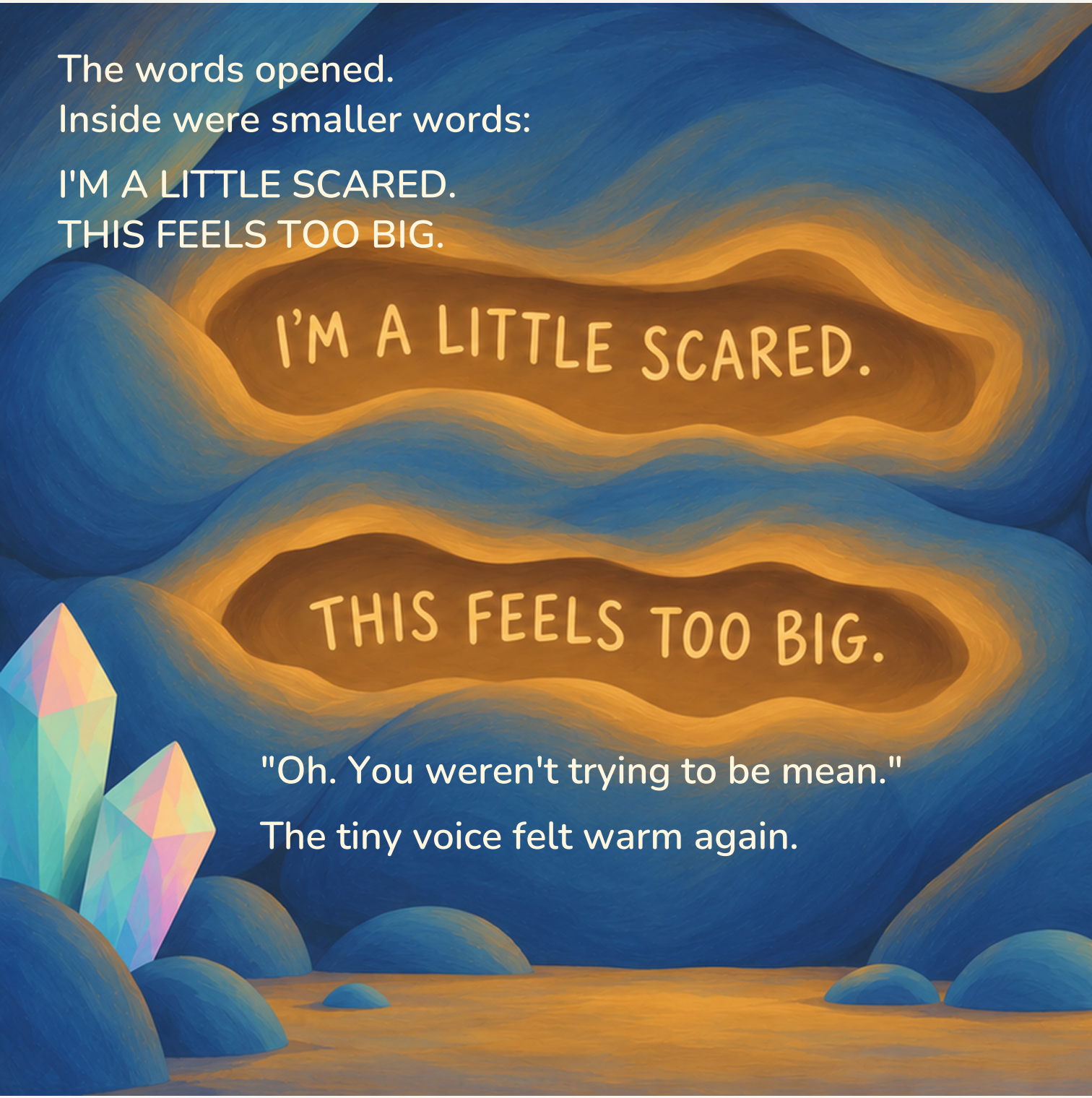
"Too many voices make it hard to hear your own,"
said the tiny voice.
[Child Name] stopped.
One slow breath.
[Child Name] listened
for the small, true voice inside.
"Listen close. I'm still here."
And there it was:
a quiet path.

The path split in two.
One way was smooth and shiny.
It looked easy.
The other was plain and steep.
[Child Name] looked at the shiny path.
It was pretty.
But something inside felt tight.
A deep breath.
"Not that way," whispered the tiny voice.

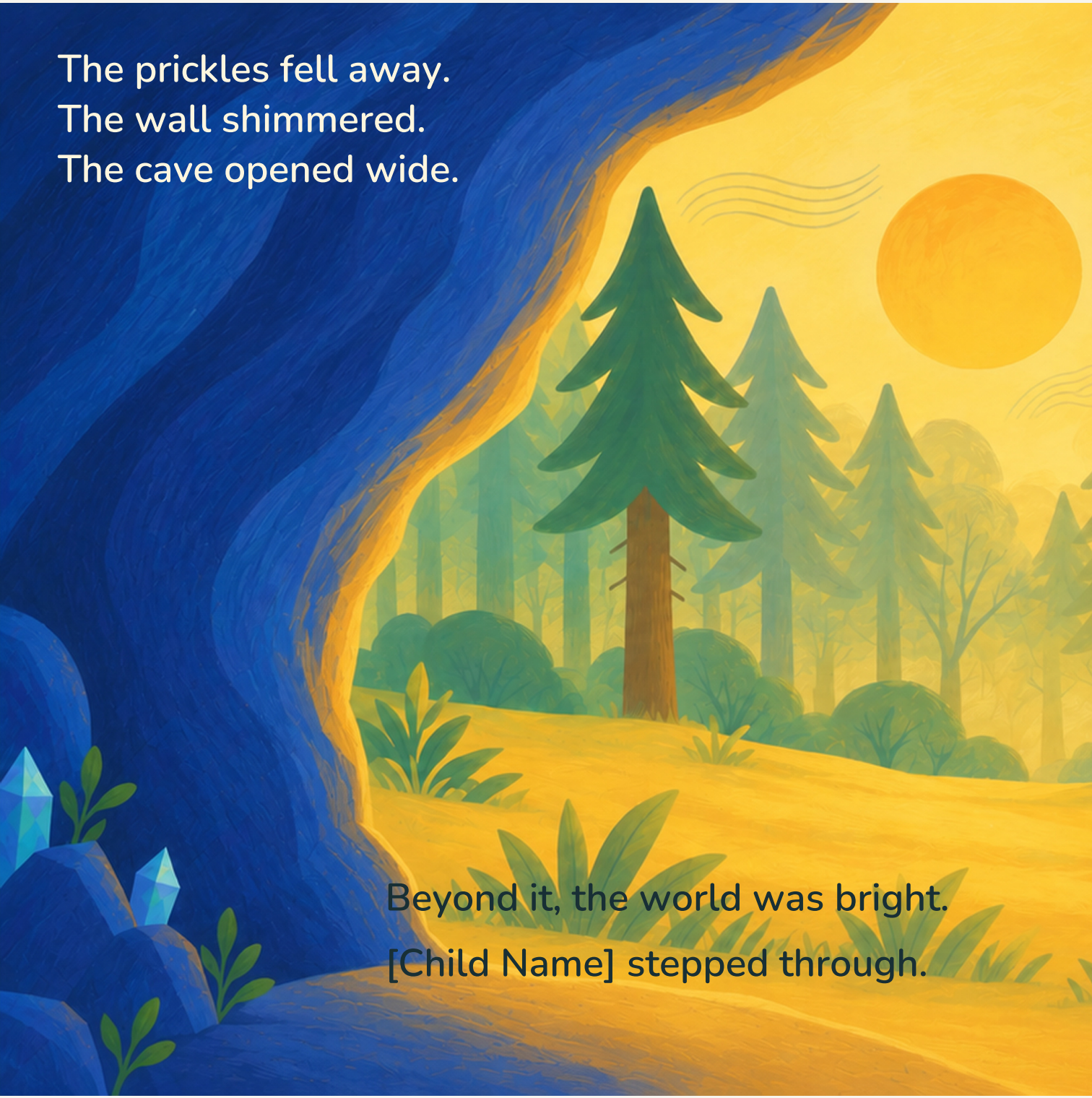

[Child Name] chose the steep path.
Up,
and up,
and up.
At the top, a cave glittered.
[Child Name] stepped closer.

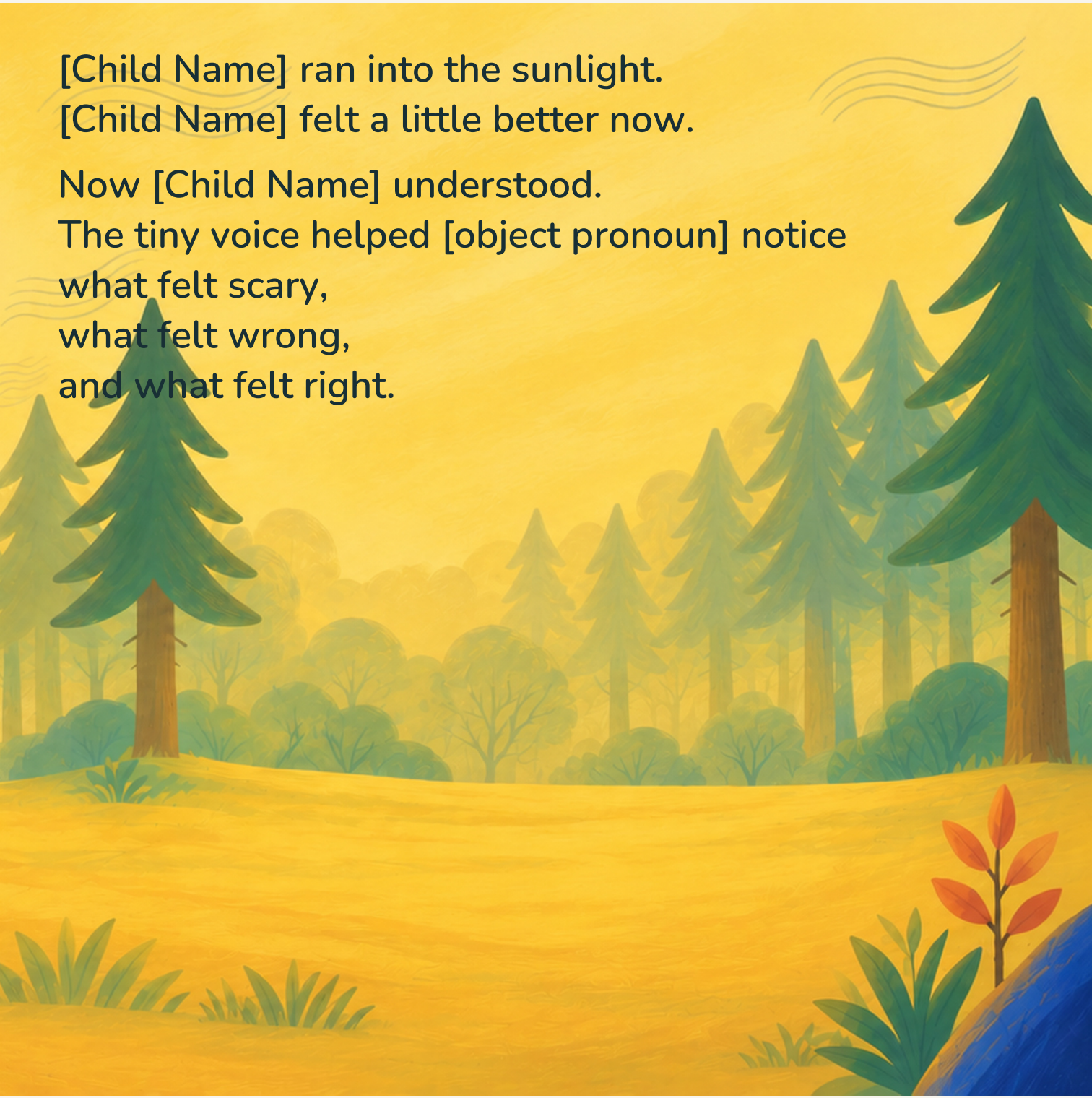
[Child Name] felt scared.
[Child Name]'s tummy felt tight.
"YOU CAN'T!"
"YOU'RE TOO LITTLE!"
The tiny voice echoed through the cave.
YOU CAN'T!
YOU'RE TOO LITTLE!
A wall blocked the path.
The same words glowed on it
in big, prickly letters.
The tiny voice didn't sound friendly now.
"Why do you sound mean?" asked [Child Name].

The voice was quiet.
[Child Name] remembered.
One deep breath.
Then another.
The cave grew quieter.
The prickly words wiggled.
Then softened.


The words opened.
Inside were smaller words:
I'M A LITTLE SCARED.
THIS FEELS TOO BIG.
I'M A LITTLE SCARED.
THIS FEELS TOO BIG.
"Oh. You weren't trying to be mean."
The tiny voice felt warm again.

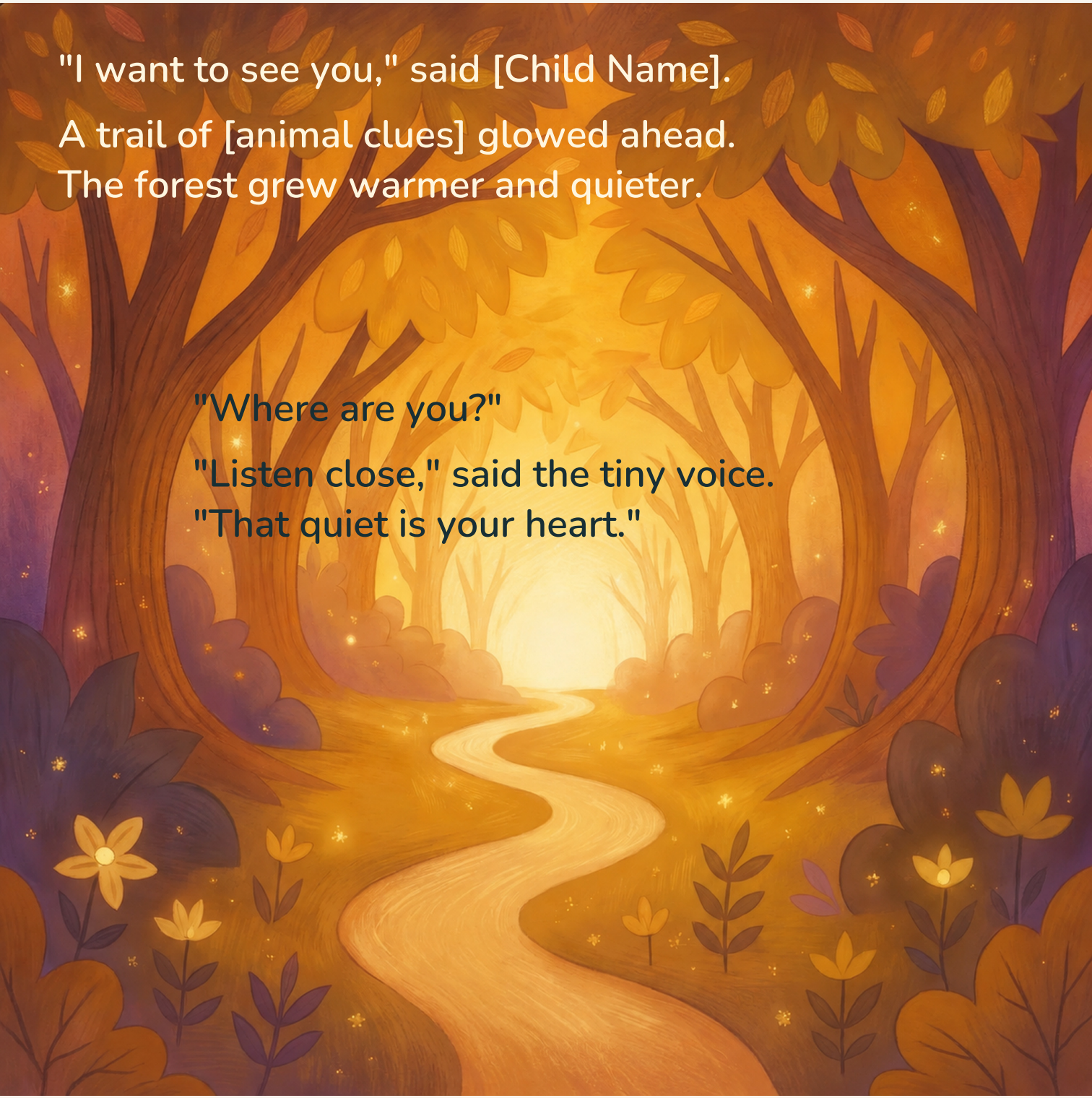
"Sometimes big feelings come out sharp,"
said the voice.
"But if you listen close,
you can hear what they are really trying to say."

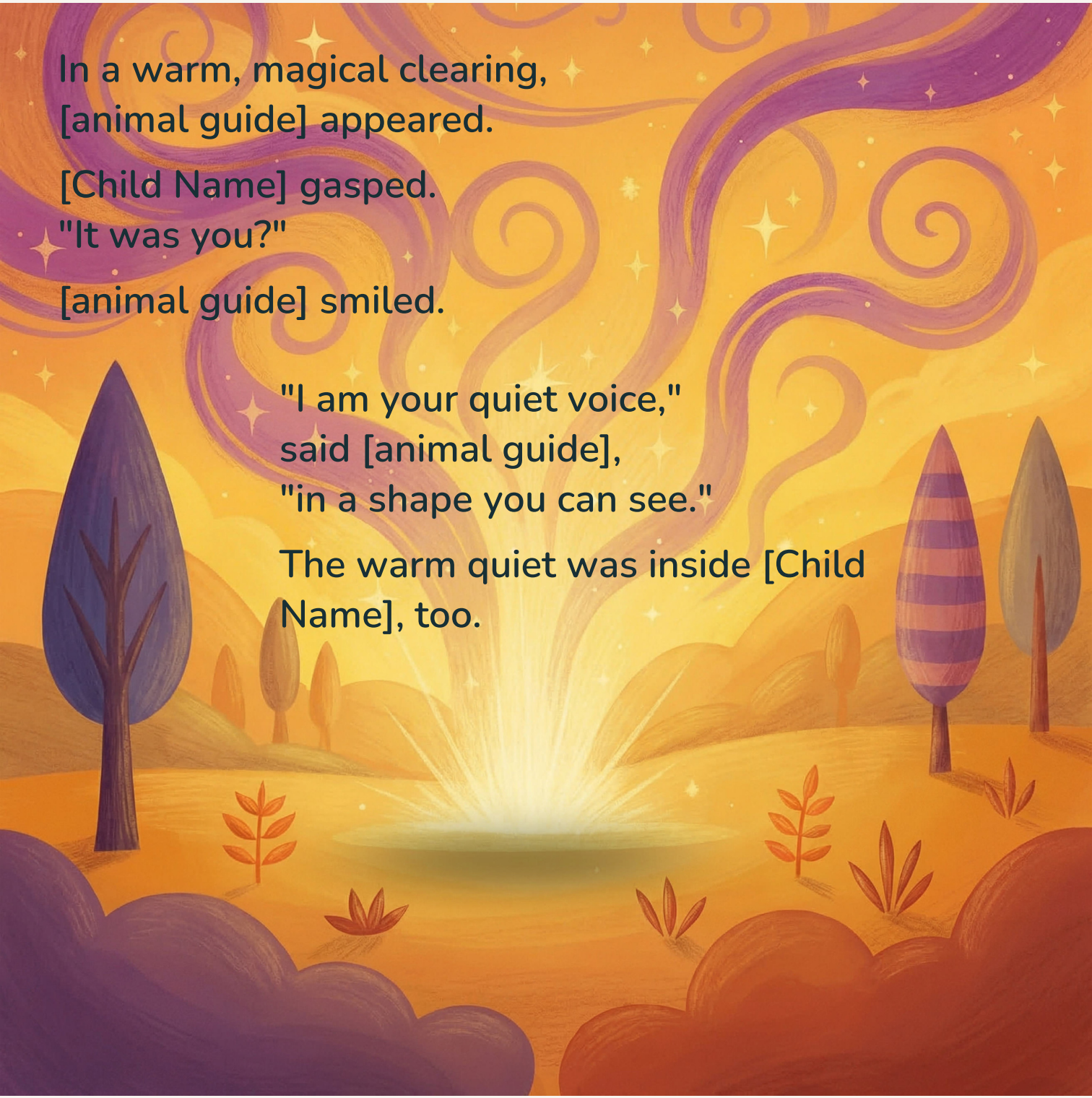

The prickles fell away.
The wall shimmered.
The cave opened wide.
Beyond it, the world was bright.
[Child Name] stepped through.



[Child Name] ran into the sunlight.
[Child Name] felt a little better now.

Now [Child Name] understood.
The tiny voice helped [object pronoun] notice
what felt scary,
what felt wrong,
and what felt right.


"I want to see you," said [Child Name].
A trail of [animal clues] glowed ahead.
The forest grew warmer and quieter.
"Where are you?"
"Listen close," said the tiny voice.
"That quiet is your heart."



In a warm, magical clearing,
[animal guide] appeared.

[Child Name] gasped.
"It was you?"

[animal guide] smiled.

"I am your quiet voice,"
said [animal guide],
"in a shape you can see."

The warm quiet was inside [Child Name], too.

[Child Name] and [animal guide]
flew through the stars.
The magical forest grew small below.
Ahead was the park,
the ladder,
and the very, very tall slide.
[animal guide] stayed close.
So did the quiet voice.

[Child Name] was back at the top.

The slide still looked long.
The slide still looked fun.
The slide still looked very, very tall.

"Your turn!"
"Go!"
"It's fun!"

[Child Name]'s tummy flipped.

This time, [Child Name] knew what to do.

Pause.
Breathe.
Listen close.

The quiet voice was there.

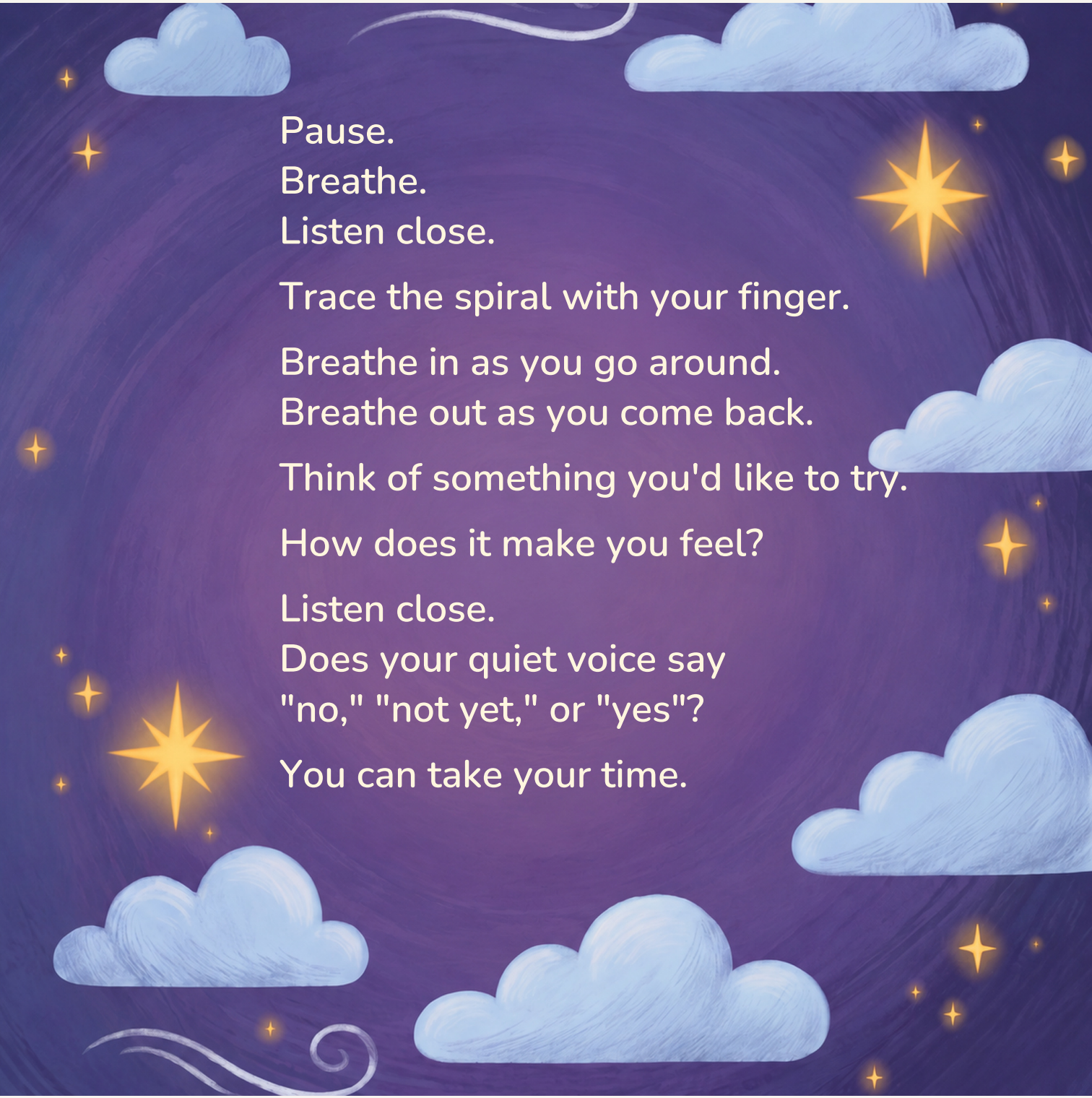
Small and warm.

"Not yet," it said.
"Almost."

[Child Name] looked at the child
waiting behind [object pronoun].

"You go first," said [Child Name].
"I'm almost ready."

And this time,
[Child Name] smiled.


Pause.
Breathe.
Listen close.
Trace the spiral with your finger.
Breathe in as you go around.
Breathe out as you come back.
Think of something you'd like to try.
How does it make you feel?
Listen close.
Does your quiet voice say
"no," "not yet," or "yes"?
You can take your time.

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For grown-ups

Ask your child:
"Was there a time today when you felt ready,
or when you wanted to wait?"

Give them time to answer.